

FUNDRAIS

FOR THE
SHLUCHA
WHO'D
RATHER
NOT



ING



CONTRIBUTORS

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Many shluchos, while happy to take on almost any responsibility their shlichus calls for, prefer to leave the emotional and personal risks that come with fundraising to their husbands. However, as

women, shluchos have certain distinct advantages when it comes to fundraising, and their help can often be not only valuable but crucial. Here are some surprisingly simple roles that shluchos can take in order to bring their feminine skills to the table without having to sit in the driver's seat.

The Shlucha as the Partner

Mrs. Sara Esther Paltiel, shlucha to Port Washington, New

York for more than 20 years, says that, while her husband does all the cultivating of possible donors, "I jump on the bandwagon when he's already riding." Most shluchim go solo to a baal habos; if the shlucha goes along with him and is even just physically there, the two give each other chizuk that neither can have alone.

What's more, seeing a husband-wife team impresses a baal habos. He might be pleasantly surprised that a Chossid would have such a relationship with his wife, or it might inspire him to cultivate a more supportive relationship with his *own* wife, both of which people appreciate.

TWO ARE
GREATER
THAN ONE

Additionally, as a woman, the shlucha adds a new dimension of communication and connection just by being there. The baal habos (or baal habosta) will connect to the shlucha, simply because the shlucha is a woman, in a way that is not possible for the shliach. Women bring out a more personal and caring feeling than men do.

"It's important to note that the husband and wife have to review who does what, when, and how," advises Rabbi Shalom Moshe Paltiel, Mrs. Paltiel's husband. It is also vital that they act in concert during the talk with the baal habos. If the shliach is now going to do the Ask, and the shlucha suddenly brings up kids and other topics, "you could kill it," as Rabbi Paltiel says. It is a balancing act; the shliach and shlucha must be sensitive to each other, as well as to the baal habos.

At times, Mrs. Paltiel sees that the baal habos's eyes gleam for something her husband said. "Now, what if it went straight over

my husband's head, but I sensed it? I will steer the direction in that way," she says. "As women, we're more intuitive, and we can sense where the baal habos wants to go."

Rabbi Paltiel is especially compelled to bring his wife along if it's a meeting with high stakes. It's more powerful and makes for a friendlier, more sociable, less defensive atmosphere, and the supporter doesn't feel that he is there just to get hit for a sum of money. Rabbi Paltiel sometimes even asks his wife to make the Ask. However, this does not fit the personality of every shlucha, he says, and shluchos shouldn't feel "less than" if they aren't comfortable participating in such ways. Every shlucha has her own skills.

"We've had occasion where we had a bumpy road with some of our serious supporters," notes Rabbi Paltiel. If a big supporter who is more invested doesn't like something that the shliach did or said, he can get very upset. "My wife has been very helpful in ironing things out, and sometimes the fact that we retained them as friends and even supporters was because of her."

It's subtle, Mrs. Paltiel admits. Because it is a more social atmosphere, the meeting is less formal at the outset, more like a conversation. Thus, everyone is calm, relaxed, and enjoying. Then, at the right time, the husband says, "Okay, let's discuss the gift," getting down to business. While the shliach takes over at this time, it is the *shlucha's* presence and input that have set the stage for the optimum outcome.

"Look," says Rabbi Paltiel, "there's a reason the Aibershter made it that a husband and wife need each other in every way, including this way."

PUT THE
FUN BACK IN
FUNDRAISING

The Shlucha as the Event Planner

"If the shlucha is uncomfortable,"
says Rabbi Sholom

Ber Lipskar, shliach to Surfside, FL,

"she shouldn't force herself to go to fundraising opportunities with her husband." On the other hand, she may excel at organizing social and educational activities, such as sisterhoods, learning classes for women, or luncheons that allow participants to buy into the organization. While such events are not set up for the sole purpose of fundraising, shluchos can use such events to create an environment where fundraising can take place. Not only do people enjoy the event, but they are *happy* to give money. "It's a different kind of money than for a building, which is often more of a shliach's role," says Rabbi Lipskar.

Rabbi Lipskar believes shluchos can be particularly effective in raising funds for projects that require a sense of nurturing, such as raising kallah funds, arranging an event for kids with special needs or single

parents who need special attention, or even beautifying the Chabad House. "People often make large gifts because they're donating to a project that's really close to their hearts," notes Rabbi Paltiel. "A woman does that better than a man."

About six years ago, Mrs. Chanie Kaller, shlucha to Sunny Isles Beach, Florida, earned a surprise windfall through the invitations she sent for her husband's surprise 30th birthday party. She was aware that her Russian community would likely come with extravagant gifts, so she made small, simple cards and wrote a "cute little poem that asked everybody, instead of bringing gifts, to make a donation to the shul and to help me reach \$30,000 for his 30th birthday." It turned out that people were very excited about the meaning of the fundraising drive. "Everybody came through. That's really all I had to do."



She is confident her modesty will only show him she's strong in her belief, and if anything, he'll respect her more.

**TEACH FIRST
ASK LATER**

The Shlucha as the Teacher

Every time a shlucha raises funds from someone, she should first make sure to teach him or her something,

Rabbi Lipskar adds. That way, she makes a contribution to that person's life, besides the fact that the person becomes a vehicle for charity.

"For each [baal habos] whom you want to cultivate for fundraising, you must have a regular learning program with that baal habos on some level," he says, adding that it can be for even 15 minutes. The shlucha should prepare properly beforehand and think about what she will say. This should be one-on-one (if the conversation is with a woman). It will bring her close to Yiddishkeit and Torah, and, for the donor, the project will become her own project, not just a donation to a friendly rabbi and rebbetzin.

**JUST BE
SUPPORTIVE**

The Shlucha as the Wife

A shlucha can also help her husband prepare for a meeting even by just listening, without giving advice, to

help him develop his thoughts. Should I do lunch? Dinner? Coffee? Should I tell him this? Ask him that? Ask him for this amount or that amount? "Just letting him say it out loud is really helpful," notes Mrs. Paltiel. "Like any problem, when you talk it out, it's not always the advice you get; it's hearing yourself."

For Rabbi Sholom Duchman of Colel Chabad in Brooklyn, New York, which feeds 5,000 families every day, fundraising for Israel is his only shlichus. >>

DEALING WITH CHALLENGES

When the Answer Is No

How can a shlucha deal with rejection? "Of course, you feel, 'oy vey,'" says Mrs. Bassie Shemtov, founder, with her husband Levi, of Friendship Circle International, as well as the Friendship Circle in West Bloomfield, MI. "I learned long ago that you have to keep going to many foundations and many places and just let it go when they say no. It happens too often to get upset about it. It's not like every person says yes, but, boruch Hashem, the stronger you become, the more you grow and the more people *do* say yes. It evens out." Mrs. Shemtov should know; her *Walk4Friendship* fundraiser has won nearly 50 corporate sponsors. Still, "it's tough in the beginning. You need experience; people need to see what you've done."

Mrs. Liba Andrusier, shlucha to Albany, NY and director of the Albany Friendship Circle, agrees. "It definitely gets easier as you prove yourself," she explains. "If you jump into it with enthusiasm, emeskeit, and a positive attitude, you'll be successful." She continues, "Optimism is contagious, and even a 'no' is success; you've reached out and made a connection to another person, and you never know what will come around. If you're real and whatever you're doing is successful, most people want to be a part of it. You just have to really believe it, show them you believe it, and be passionate about what you're saying and doing."

Connecting Without Connecting

How Not to Shake His Hand

"Since we live five minutes from the capitol of New York State, we have the opportunity to go meet with prominent elected officials such as the governor, senators, and the like." Mrs. Andrusier sets up the meetings, but once there, she is expected to shake hands. "With politicians specifically, I will try to let the office staff know ahead of time that I cannot shake hands, in order to help make the transition of the first meeting go smoothly." When she meets a woman for the first time and give her a handshake, it's much easier because she can break through a barrier right away, she explains. "[With a man,] when not able to shake, I give a very warm smile and say, 'I'm sorry, I don't shake for religious reasons, but I feel it in the heart.'"

Of course, this can make the introduction less comfortable, but Mrs. Andrusier always tells herself that a person's reaction to her tznius won't stop her. "If right after [telling him you can't shake hands], you give a compliment about his child, or find some way to get super involved in the conversation with a smile, it usually fixes it up quickly." She is confident her modesty will only show him she's strong in her belief, and, if anything, he'll respect her more.

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Women Can Donate, Too!

A FANTASTIC REASON FOR SHLUCHOS TO TAKE THE FUNDRAISING WHEEL

Think men are the only ones who want to give? Think again. Jewish women donors have been changing things in the world of Jewish philanthropy in a big way since the mid-1990s. Collectively, they have allocated millions of dollars during the past 15 years to programs all over the world that serve Jewish women and girls. And this isn't by default; these women are actively looking for ways to give to their chosen causes. Why? Because doing so turns up the volume on their collective voice, thereby deepening their impact on the world.

Take, for example, the seventeen Jewish women's funds and foundations who began working together in the past several months to make one massive collective grant towards "Rights, Inclusion and Representation" of Jewish women and girls. More than \$160,000 has been collected [at the time of this writing] for for a 2012-2014 grants cycle. What's more, it is the women themselves who are working to find even more grantees.

(Source: Engaging Female Donors: Learning from Jewish Women's Foundations, an article by Sara Rose Gorfinkel and Emily Muskovitz Sweet, March 12, 2012, eJP)

His baalei batim see that he and his wife Faigy are partners in the sense that she is a wife and mother and a shlucha of the Rebbe. "My wife helps me as a wife," he relates. "It's very important for my fundraising—aside from just being a man, a normal human being—that I have a wife and a family." Mrs. Duchman helps just by being herself and being there with him.

Mrs. Duchman acts as both a host and a guest. The Duchmans go out to dinner together with their baalei batim; they are friends with them. Most of their donors have been at the Duchmans' home, whether for Purim, Sukkos, Chanuka, or a dinner, or they get together when they make a dedication for Israel, etc. It is important to them that his wife is a part of it.

"My wife knows all my baalei batim, and everyone is very fond of my wife," Rabbi Duchman relates. "In general, our fundraising is to create a partnership, and a wife is a very important part of that. But my wife is not involved when I ask for funds. She is involved in cultivation."

"As a partner," he continues, "it is very important for the cultivation that people see the family, the family structure, how we are. They're connected to the kids; they're connected to the guests, to the Rebbe. It's very powerful." 

Written by Mrs. Rivkah Lewin